

It should be noted that this doesn't merely consider synonyms, which it already used to do anyway, but also considers neighbouring terms in the search as well as the immediate past queries.

For example, once a search for "Terminator lead actor" returns Arnold Schwarzenegger to you, you can follow up with "How tall is he" and Google will understand that you're referring to what you just found out. Similarly you could work with your favourite sports team, looking "FC Barcelona fixtures" first, and then asking for their top goalscorer.

It's important to remember that while this integration of natural language processing (NLP) did produce more relevant contextual results, it did not impact existing SEO techniques being used as such. Indeed, this was taken up because there was a shift in the kind of queries being asked. Instead of people asking for "Walmart stock price", people are asking Google to "navigate to the nearest Walmart" instead, because they're doing so not at their desktops at home, but walking down the street speaking these queries into their smartphones. And Google has coped with this magnificently.

"Okay Google, walk to the nearest metro station," I asked, and was immediately directed to the correct one out of the three fairly close options I had, the maximum difference being a couple of hundred meters or so. It was a pleasant surprise. With Google's flagship, the Nexus 6P, clearly focusing on aggressive battery management and having a larger capacity overall, the company is making life for a lot of power users a breeze. The more bought into the Android/Google ecosystem you are, the more seamless everything feels. Continuity and reliability were never an issue. In fact, in the past few years, with the advent of the wonderfully expressive and clean material design philosophy and a largely consistent and powerful NLP mechanism running behind the scenes of the classic white Google search bar, it has become a more personalised and, dare we say, more intuitive search engine than ever before.

Of course, Google's emphasis on original and helpful content has always remained its core advice to all websites, and Hummingbird was not focused on ranking down poor websites as such, but instead was more about walking in the shoes of the users to get at the meaning behind their questions.

Caught up in semantics: "Things, not strings"

In 2012, Google introduced a system of information organisation that they call their "Knowledge Graph" to the world. Searching can be thought of in two ways. One way is to ask where certain words can be found in a really